

Phase 3 — The Focus

Select useful information, shift attention as the task changes, and build a practical preparation and refocus plan.

Reading and practice chapter

Use this chapter beside the learning website or as a reading route through the same lessons. Save written responses in the website or the format directed by your teacher.

Worked examples are labelled. Try the learner questions before checking the answer and feedback section at the end.

Fictional sport, academic and artistic examples are welcome. No private health details, personal beliefs or claims of perfect confidence are needed.

Reconciled learner reading chapter.

Contents

The phase case and learning goals	3
02 · What attention does	3
03 · Four ways to focus	6
04 · Shift as the task changes	9
05 · Observe without judging yourself	13
06 · Cue words and anchors	16
07 · Prepare your attention	19
08 · Notice, reset and return	22
09 · Practise a flexible focus plan	25
10 · Decision practice	30
11 · My Focus Plan	32
12 · Written review	37
Final checkpoint	38
Glossary and sources	42
Answers and feedback	44

The phase case

Jordan returns to the next free throw

Jordan is a fictional Grade 10 basketball player. During open play, Jordan needs to notice the ball, defenders and available teammates. At the free-throw line, the task changes. Jordan has practised a brief setup: find the line, release extra shoulder tension, look at the chosen rim target and use the cue “smooth.”

At the last school practice, Jordan missed a shot after a rushed setup. Jordan then thought, “I always fail when people watch,” looked toward a spectator and missed the teammate's signal for the next drill. The coach observed the rushed setup and offered a chance to practise it again. One missed cue does not tell us its only cause. In this case, Jordan's own account supplies additional evidence about attention.

The next practice includes a planned interruption: the drill order changes before Jordan's turn. You will help Jordan prepare, notice the new demand and select a useful next cue. Treat the case as fictional. An academic parallel is preparing to explain a graph after a classroom presentation order changes. An artistic parallel is returning to an agreed musical entry after an interruption. You may use one of these settings throughout your work.

Your opening response

Describe Jordan's task before a free throw and during open play. What useful information changes between those moments?

Learning goals

- I can explain selection, sustaining attention and shifting using a specific task.
- I can distinguish the four attention quadrants in a clearly stated moment.
- I can explain a sequence of attention shifts and the trigger for each change.
- I can use an attributed coaching framework without treating it as a measured equation.
- I can select a cue and anchor that fit a particular task.
- I can explain the purpose of each step in a before-performance routine.
- I can write an adaptable if–then plan that returns attention to useful information.
- I can propose a suitable variation and explain what evidence would guide an adjustment.

02 · What attention does

Choose useful information, stay with it, and notice when the task changes.

Learning goal: I can explain selection, sustaining attention and shifting using a specific task.

Before you begin: Picture a performer who has more information available than they can use at once.

Attention gives the task a place to start

A school gym contains voices, moving people, floor markings and a scoreboard. A player cannot treat every detail as equally important. **Attention** concerns how information is selected and used. **Concentration** means keeping attention with what matters for the task. It does not mean blocking out everything around you.

Four useful actions are selecting, sustaining, noticing and shifting. **Selecting** means choosing information. **Sustaining** means staying with it long enough to do the job. **Noticing** means detecting a relevant change. **Shifting** means moving attention when another cue becomes more useful. These actions often work together rather than appearing as four separate stages.

Select according to the demand

Ask, “What decision or action is needed now?” A player deciding where to pass needs different information from a player taking a free throw. A presenter explaining a graph needs to attend to its key relationship. Reading every word on a slide may compete with that job.

Useful information is **task-relevant**: it helps the current action. A distraction pulls attention toward something less useful at that moment. The same sound can serve either role. A musician may need a partner's entry cue, while an unrelated conversation adds nothing to the next phrase. Relevance depends on the task, not just whether the information is inside or outside the performer.

Capacity is limited

Trying to hold many instructions at once can make the next action unclear. “Watch everyone, remember every correction and never make a mistake” gives attention several competing jobs. A shorter cue can help organize a familiar action. It cannot supply a skill the person has not learned.

Limited capacity does not mean a person is unable to learn. It means the plan should decide what deserves attention now. During learning, there may be time to examine a movement carefully. During a familiar performance, one well-understood cue may be more usable than a list of corrections.

Notice before explaining a miss

A missed cue is an observation. Its cause is a further question. The cue might have been unclear, unexpected or hidden. The performer might have been attending elsewhere. Ask what was noticed, what the person was trying to do and whether the instructions changed.

A useful plan does not demand perfect concentration. It identifies the relevant information, provides a way to notice drift and names a return point. The next topics give more precise language for that plan.

Worked example · fictional case

One room, two different jobs

Mina is preparing a short class presentation. Before speaking, Mina checks the graph's main relationship. During the explanation, Mina notices a classmate's question. Looking at the graph was useful first; listening becomes useful next.

A phone notification is less relevant to either task. The plan is to silence it during preparation, then use “main relationship” as the opening cue. This supports selection and sustaining attention. It does not mean Mina must ignore a relevant question to prove concentration.

Try the concept checks

Choose before checking. Explanations are in Answers and feedback.

02.1 · A performer stays with the agreed rhythm through a short musical phrase. Which attention action is most directly shown?

- A. Shifting to an unrelated stimulus.
- B. Sustaining attention on a useful cue.
- C. Measuring their total mental capacity.

02.2 · A player misses a teammate's signal. What information is most useful before explaining why?

- A. The final score alone.
- B. A permanent label for the player's concentration.
- C. What the player was attending to and whether the signal was clear.

Select information for the next action

What information matters in this moment? Identify one distraction and explain why it is less useful now.

Write two to four sentences using case evidence, a choice and a reason. Save this response for Build.

03 · Four ways to focus

Describe attention by its width and its direction.

Learning goal: I can distinguish the four attention quadrants in a clearly stated moment.

Before you begin: Separate how much information is used from where that information comes from.

Two questions form four quadrants

The attention framework associated with **Robert Nideffer** combines two dimensions. **Width** describes whether attention is broad or narrow. **Direction** describes whether it is internal or external. Broad attention takes in several pieces of information. Narrow attention selects a specific cue. Internal attention concerns thoughts or bodily sensations. External attention concerns information in the surroundings.

Combine the dimensions to name four quadrants: broad-external, broad-internal, narrow-internal and narrow-external. These labels describe the focus used in a moment. They do not divide students into permanent kinds of people. A useful performer can change focus when the demand changes.

Broad-external: scan the surroundings

A basketball player scans the ball, defenders and available teammates before a pass. Several external cues matter together. That is a broad-external example. Broad does not mean noticing everything equally. It means gathering enough relevant information to read the play.

A recreational hiker checking the route, group position and nearby conditions offers another example. The situation determines which details belong in the scan. Looking around without a purpose may simply add distractions.

Broad-internal: consider information and options

During a pause, a player considers the coach's plan, the available options and an earlier pattern in the game. Those thoughts are internal, and several pieces are being considered. This is broad-internal attention.

A student organizing the argument for a presentation also uses several internal ideas. Analysis can be useful when there is time for it. The question is whether the current moment calls for planning or for carrying out the next prepared action.

Narrow-internal: one thought or sensation

During a safe pause, a performer briefly checks whether their shoulders are unnecessarily tense. The focus is internal and specific. Recalling one short cue can also be narrow-internal. This is different from repeatedly scanning every possible bodily sensation.

An internal check should have a clear purpose and an ending. After the check, the performer returns to information needed for the task. A long search for a perfect feeling may compete with preparation.

Narrow-external: one useful outside cue

A free-throw shooter looks at a chosen part of the rim. A musician watches the conductor's entry signal. Each selects a specific external cue. Narrow attention is useful here because the next action has a precise target.

No quadrant is always best. A narrow target that helps a free throw may hide useful information during open play. Judge the focus against the task rather than calling broad, narrow, internal or external attention automatically good or bad.

Worked example · fictional case

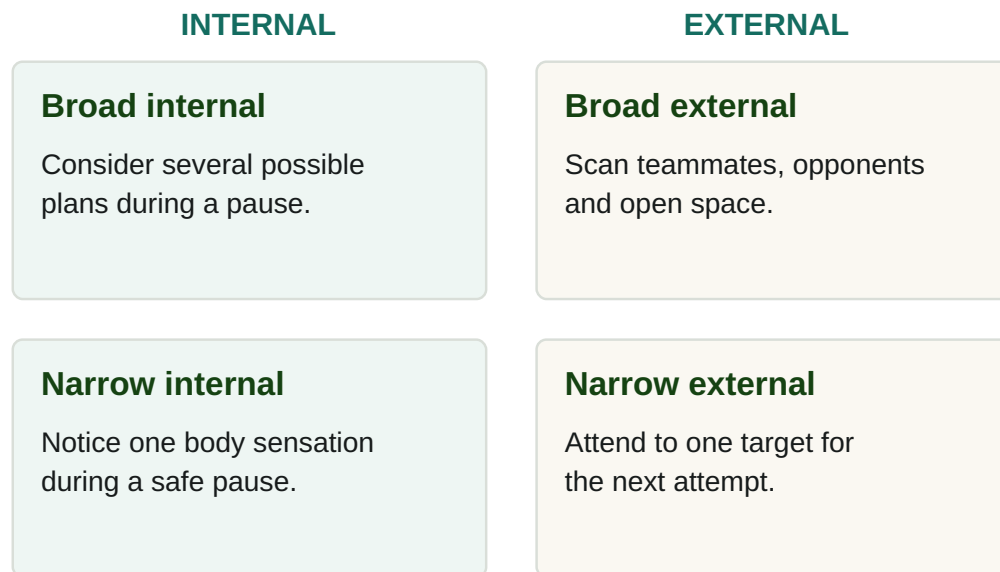
Describe the moment, not the whole athlete

Jordan is waiting at the free-throw line. During a safe pause, Jordan briefly notices extra shoulder tension. This is narrow-internal attention: one bodily cue. Jordan then looks at the chosen rim target, which is narrow-external.

The framework describes two moments in the same routine. It does not prove that Jordan belongs to an “internal type.” Once play resumes, a wider scan may be needed. The explanation must include the task and timing of each focus.

Four ways to direct attention

The useful focus depends on the task at that moment.



Broad = several cues. Narrow = one cue. Internal = thoughts or sensations. External = information in the environment.

No quadrant is permanently best. Shift when the task changes.

FIGURE 1 • THE FOUR ATTENTION QUADRANTS. Broad internal attention considers several thoughts or options. Broad external attention scans the environment. Narrow internal attention notices one thought or sensation. Narrow external attention focuses on one external cue. The task determines which focus is useful; no quadrant is permanently ideal.

Broad internal attention considers several thoughts or options. Broad external attention scans the environment. Narrow internal attention notices one thought or sensation. Narrow external attention focuses on one external cue. The task determines which focus is useful; no quadrant is permanently ideal.

Try the concept checks

Choose before checking. Explanations are in Answers and feedback.

03.1 · During a pause, a player compares several possible strategies in their thoughts. Which quadrant fits?

- A. Broad-internal.
- B. Narrow-external.
- C. Broad-external.

03.2 · During open play, Jordan needs to see defenders and available teammates before passing. Which focus fits?

- A. Narrow-internal attention to one breath.
- B. Broad-external attention to the relevant play.
- C. Narrow-external attention only to the scoreboard.

Match a quadrant to a moment

Choose the focus needed at a stated moment and explain the evidence supporting your choice.

Write two to four sentences using case evidence, a choice and a reason. Save this response for Build.

04 · Shift as the task changes

Use a change in the task as a signal to change attention.

Learning goal: I can explain a sequence of attention shifts and the trigger for each change.

Before you begin: Bring forward the four quadrants; no single quadrant is the permanent target.

A useful focus can become an old focus

During open play, Jordan scans defenders and teammates. A whistle stops the play. The coach gives a short instruction. Later, Jordan takes a free throw. Holding exactly the same focus across these moments would not meet all three demands.

An **attention shift** is a change in the information selected. It may change width, direction or both. A plan is stronger when it names what triggers the shift. “Focus better” is vague. “When the whistle stops play, listen for the instruction” links an event to a useful response.

Scan, plan, check and target

One teaching sequence begins with a broad-external scan of the situation. During a suitable pause, broad-internal attention may help the performer consider options. A brief narrow-internal check may identify an unnecessary tension signal. Narrow-external attention can then select the target for a precise next action.

This sequence is an example, not a ritual everyone must complete. Some tasks need fewer shifts. Others require repeated scanning during action. The performer should not add an internal check if it distracts from information needed for safety or execution. The task decides the sequence.

Give every transition a reason

For each moment, name the demand, the information and the trigger. A passing decision calls for information about space and teammates. A planned break permits discussion. An aiming attempt calls for the established target. The transition matters because the information needs have changed.

A musician may listen broadly to the ensemble, consider an adjustment during a pause, briefly recall the agreed count and then watch a specific entry cue. A presenter may scan the audience for a question, think through a response, choose the relevant example and point to one part of a graph. Neither situation needs a sport setting to use the framework.

Avoid two common traps

The first trap is staying with the last mistake. The result has happened, but attention remains on a judgment instead of the next demand. A brief factual review can be useful later. During the next action, use a cue that belongs to that action.

The second trap is changing focus without a reason. Constantly checking body sensations, the score and other people's reactions can create competing jobs. A prepared transition can reduce unnecessary searching, while remaining flexible when new information matters.

Check whether the shift served the task

Record what the performer intended to notice and what they actually noticed. Did the cue make the next action clearer? Was important information missed? One result does not prove that the shift caused success or failure. Use the observation to decide what to keep, clarify or practise again.

Worked example · fictional case

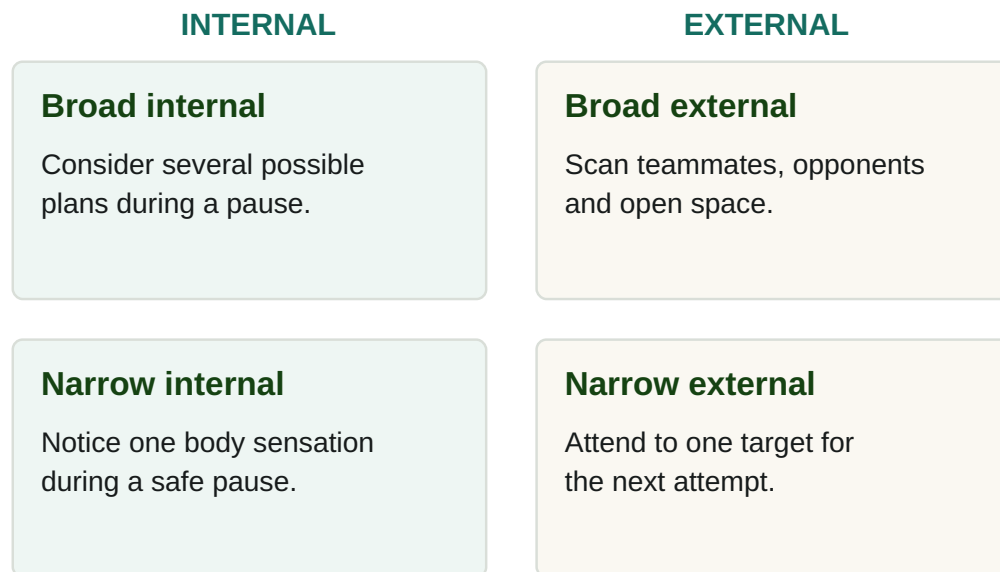
The whistle changes the job

Jordan scans the ball and available teammates during play. When the whistle sounds, the task becomes listening to the official rather than continuing the pass. At the free-throw line, Jordan uses the familiar setup and chosen target.

A useful plan names those transitions. It does not instruct Jordan to repeat all four quadrants while the ball is live. Attention shifts because the task changes, not because completing a four-box sequence earns a better result.

Four ways to direct attention

The useful focus depends on the task at that moment.



Broad = several cues. Narrow = one cue. Internal = thoughts or sensations. External = information in the environment.

No quadrant is permanently best. Shift when the task changes.

FIGURE 1 • THE FOUR ATTENTION QUADRANTS. Broad internal attention considers several thoughts or options. Broad external attention scans the environment. Narrow internal attention notices one thought or sensation. Narrow external attention focuses on one external cue. The task determines which focus is useful; no quadrant is permanently ideal.

Broad internal attention considers several thoughts or options. Broad external attention scans the environment. Narrow internal attention notices one thought or sensation. Narrow external attention focuses on one external cue. The task determines which focus is useful; no quadrant is permanently ideal.

Try the concept checks

Choose before checking. Explanations are in Answers and feedback.

04.1 · What makes an attention-shift plan more usable?

- A. Using the same quadrant for every situation.
- B. Changing focus whenever any thought appears.
- C. Naming the task change that triggers a new focus.

04.2 · A planned solo becomes a duet just before rehearsal. What should change first?

- A. Identify the partner cues and revise the attention sequence.
- B. Keep the solo plan unchanged to protect consistency.
- C. Add more internal checks regardless of the new task.

Explain the transitions

Describe how attention changes from scanning, to planning, to a brief body check, to the next target.

Write two to four sentences using case evidence, a choice and a reason. Save this response for Build.

05 · Observe without judging yourself

Replace a judgment about the whole person with information about an attempt.

Learning goal: I can use an attributed coaching framework without treating it as a measured equation.

Before you begin: Recall the difference between an observed action and a claim about identity.

A mistake and its interpretation are different

“The ball landed short” describes a result. “I am useless” judges the whole person. The second statement gives little direction for the next attempt. It may also compete with information the performer needs. A useful response starts with what happened and what can be examined.

Nonjudgmental observation means describing a relevant feature without turning it into a verdict on personal worth. It does not mean pretending the attempt was correct. A performer can acknowledge a missed shot and ask for feedback without calling themselves a failure.

Gallwey's Inner Game framework

Timothy Gallwey uses the coaching framework **performance = potential – interference**. Here, interference means influences that get in the way of using a learned skill. Excessive self-criticism or trying to control every small movement may be examples in a particular case.

Treat the equation as an organizing idea, not arithmetic. This lesson does not measure a student's potential or subtract a numerical amount of interference. Many other features of a task matter, including instruction, preparation, skill and conditions.

The framework uses **Self 1** for the telling, judging voice and **Self 2** for the performer using learned capabilities. These are model labels. They are not two brain structures or two separate people inside a learner. Their purpose is to help discuss how commentary can compete with execution.

Analysis still has a place

A beginner may need a demonstration and careful attention to a movement. A performer may need to analyse an error at a sensible break. “Trust the skill” cannot replace learning a missing skill or listening to accurate feedback.

The distinction concerns timing and purpose. During practice, a coach can explain one correction. During a familiar attempt, the performer may use one understood cue rather than rehearse a long list of technical instructions. Afterwards, the action can be reviewed again.

Move from judgment to evidence

Use three parts: observation, possible explanation and next action. Keep the explanation open when the evidence is limited. “My setup was shorter than usual; I may have rushed; I will use the agreed setup cue next time” is more useful than “I always choke.”

A school example works the same way. “I left out the evidence for my claim” identifies something to revise. “I am bad at every subject” does not. A realistic observation can support a clear correction while preserving the fact that the work needs improvement.

The aim is not to remove every unhelpful thought. Notice when a thought pulls attention away, then return to a task-relevant action. Review the pattern without grading yourself on whether your mind felt perfectly quiet.

Worked example · fictional case**Keep the error; change the conclusion**

After the missed free throw, Jordan says, “I always fail when people watch.” The coach observed a rushed setup. A stronger statement is, “I shortened my setup on that attempt. I will use the familiar preparation cue before the next shot.”

This does not promise the next shot will score. It identifies an action Jordan can try and review. If the setup remains unclear, instruction and practice are needed. A positive phrase alone would not fix that gap.

Gallwey’s Inner Game framework

An attributed coaching model—not a measured calculation.

Performance = potential – interference

Use it to ask what is getting in the way.

Self 1

The judging or
instructing voice in the
model.

Self 2

The learned capacity for
action in the model.

These names are not brain structures. Useful instruction during learning is different from overthinking a familiar action.

Observe the task. Keep useful feedback. Choose the next cue.

FIGURE 2 · GALLWEY’S ATTRIBUTED COACHING FRAMEWORK. Gallwey’s performance equation is a coaching framework, not a measured subtraction. Self 1 and Self 2 are names within that framework, not parts of the brain. Specific observation and a useful cue can guide a familiar task while instruction remains important during learning.

Gallwey's performance equation is a coaching framework, not a measured subtraction. Self 1 and Self 2 are names within that framework, not parts of the brain. Specific observation and a useful cue can guide a familiar task while instruction remains important during learning.

Try the concept checks

Choose before checking. Explanations are in Answers and feedback.

05.1 · How should Self 1 and Self 2 be described in this lesson?

- A. Two anatomical brain systems measured by the game.
- B. Labels in Gallwey's coaching framework.
- C. Permanent personality categories.

05.2 · Which response uses nonjudgmental observation?

- A. Nothing went wrong, so no correction is needed.
- B. I am not a natural performer and cannot improve.
- C. My entry was late; I will practise the agreed count and check it.

From judgment to observation

Turn a global judgment into a specific observation and next action. Explain why the new wording is more useful.

Write two to four sentences using case evidence, a choice and a reason. Save this response for Build.

06 · Cue words and anchors

Give attention a short, meaningful place to return.

Learning goal: I can select a cue and anchor that fit a particular task.

Before you begin: A cue must connect to an action the performer understands and has practised.

A cue is a reminder, not a complete lesson

A **cue word** is a short word or phrase used to direct attention or support action. It works best when the performer already understands its meaning. “Smooth” may remind Jordan of a practised release. For someone who has not learned that action, the word may be too vague.

A useful cue is short enough to use in the available moment. “Change your feet, shoulders, hands and timing” gives several competing instructions. During learning, those features may need separate explanation. During a familiar attempt, select the cue most relevant to the identified task.

Instructional and motivational purposes

An **instructional cue** directs technique, timing or relevant information. “See the target,” “steady count” and “main evidence” can serve that purpose in different settings. The phrase should tell the performer something useful about what to do.

A **motivational cue** supports effort or commitment. “Keep going” or “commit to this phrase” can serve that purpose. It should not pressure someone to ignore a real need for support. A more intense phrase is not automatically a better one.

Classify a cue by the job it does, not only its wording. “Finish” could remind a musician to sustain a final note or encourage a student to complete a familiar task. The explanation of its purpose makes the distinction clear.

An anchor gives attention a return point

An **anchor** is a chosen cue, sensation or action that helps the performer return to the task. A rim target, an agreed musical count or a key word on a speaking card can be an anchor. The performer should know when to use it and what comes next.

An anchor is not a lucky object that guarantees a result. It is also not necessarily a body check. Sometimes the best return point is external information. Choose the anchor from the task rather than adding a complicated routine because it sounds professional.

Plan the return

Use the sentence, “When I notice ____, I will return to ____, then ____.” The first part identifies a signal. The second selects the anchor. The third connects attention to action. For example, “When I start replaying the last error, I will look at the agreed entry mark, count in and begin the next phrase.”

The plan must allow flexibility. A usual visual anchor may not be available in a different room. Identify an alternative that serves the same purpose. Test the cue during appropriate practice and review whether it made the action clearer. Do not claim success merely because the phrase was repeated.

Worked example · fictional case

Two cues, one selection

Jordan considers “commit” and “see the rim target.” The first supports effort. The second directs attention to specific external information. Jordan's stated problem is looking toward a spectator before shooting, so the target cue is a better first match for this case.

The anchor is the chosen part of the rim, not the word alone. After finding it, Jordan follows the practised setup. If Jordan has not learned the setup, the plan also needs instruction; repeating the cue is not enough.

Try the concept checks

Choose before checking. Explanations are in Answers and feedback.

06.1 · A cue reminds a singer to enter on the agreed count. What is its main purpose?

- A. Instructional: directing timing.
- B. Motivational: raising effort regardless of timing.
- C. Diagnostic: measuring anxiety.

06.2 · The usual speaking card is unavailable. What is the most useful adjustment?

- A. Assume the presentation cannot be attempted.
- B. Choose another brief anchor for the same main idea.
- C. Add every remembered correction to the opening cue.

Choose a usable return point

Choose a cue and anchor for the next action. Explain why they fit this task.

Write two to four sentences using case evidence, a choice and a reason. Save this response for Build.

07 · Prepare your attention

Build a short sequence that connects preparation to the first action.

Learning goal: I can explain the purpose of each step in a before-performance routine.

Before you begin: Use an existing skill and a realistic amount of preparation time.

A routine organizes attention

A **preperformance routine** is a planned sequence used before an action. It can include checking the task, choosing a cue and preparing to begin. Its purpose is to make the next action clearer. Completing a routine does not guarantee a successful outcome or require every nervous feeling to disappear.

Keep the routine suited to the setting. A free throw provides a different pause from a moving team play. A classroom presentation may allow a short check before speaking. A musical entry may need immediate attention to a conductor. A routine that takes too long can interfere with the task it is meant to support.

Begin with information and preparation

First identify what the performer must know. Where is the action taking place? What is the starting cue? Is a rule or instruction unclear? Clarifying a task can be more useful than repeating a motivational phrase over missing information.

Preparation also includes skills and materials. A presenter checks that the needed example is ready. A player knows the agreed setup. A musician has practised the entry. Mental preparation works with those resources; it does not replace them.

Give each step one job

A simple routine might have three parts: prepare, direct and begin. During preparation, the performer checks the task and uses any familiar, comfortable settling action that is useful. During direction, they choose the relevant cue. During beginning, they commit to the next practised action.

The names matter less than the purpose. Explain what each step directs attention toward. “Prepare” is too broad without a detail. “Check the starting position and listen for the official’s signal” is a task-based instruction.

Use a complete fictional example

For a school presentation, the routine could be: check the graph and speaking order; recall the cue “main relationship”; look toward the audience and begin the practised opening. The student may still feel uncertain. The sequence provides an action without demanding a perfect feeling first.

For sport, a brief body check belongs only at a suitable pause. Do not add breathing drills during swimming, active play or another task needing full attention. Describing a routine in writing is an acceptable way to demonstrate its purpose in this preview.

Practise and revise the routine

A routine becomes more usable when its steps are understood and rehearsed. Try a hypothetical walkthrough or an appropriately supervised practice. Observe whether the sequence fits the available time and whether the final cue belongs to the task.

Record the routine separately from the result. One successful attempt does not prove that the routine caused success. One mistake does not automatically make the routine useless. Use specific observations to choose a sensible adjustment.

Worked example · fictional case

Prepare, direct, begin

Jordan's routine is: check the line and starting position; briefly release unnecessary shoulder tension during the pause; find the rim target, use “smooth” and shoot. Each step has a purpose. The final attention is on the target and familiar action, not on continually checking feelings.

A teammate uses a different routine. That is not a problem if it fits their task. The assignment asks Jordan to explain and adapt the chosen sequence, not prove there is one correct ritual for everybody.

Prepare attention before performance

Keep each step connected to the next task.

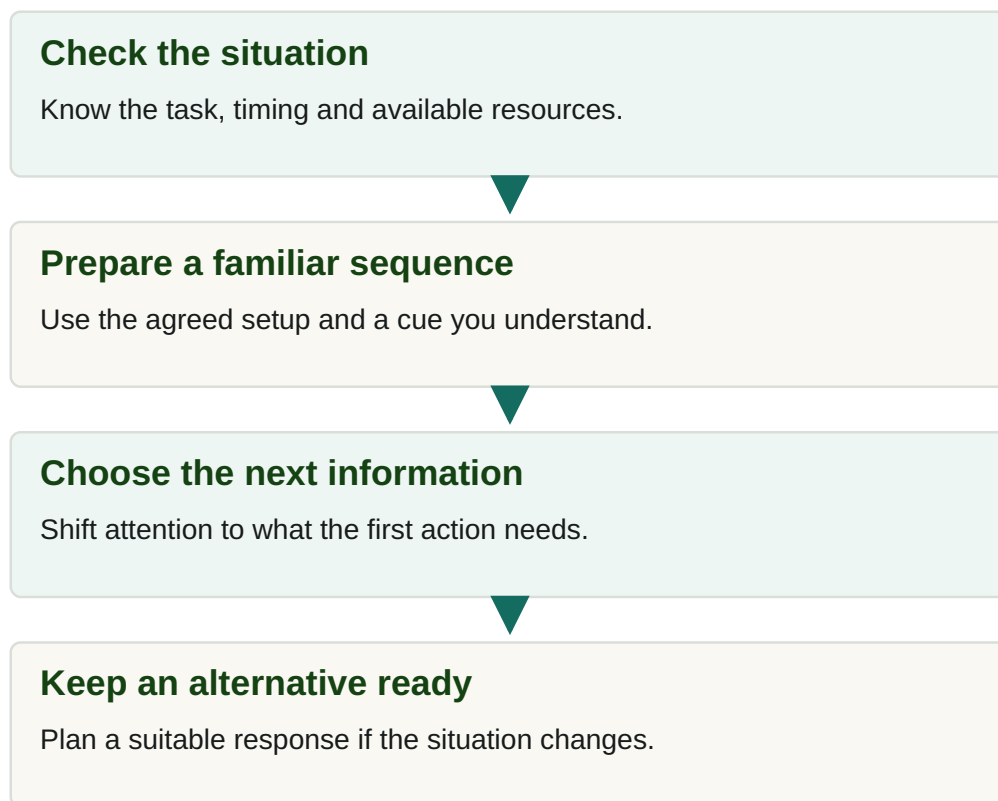


FIGURE 3 · PREPARE ATTENTION BEFORE PERFORMANCE. A preparation routine checks the situation, uses a familiar sequence, directs attention to the next information and includes an alternative for a likely disruption. It is a plan to use and adjust, not a promise to eliminate uncertainty.

A preparation routine checks the situation, uses a familiar sequence, directs attention to the next information and includes an alternative for a likely disruption. It is a plan to use and adjust, not a promise to eliminate uncertainty.

Try the concept checks

Choose before checking. Explanations are in Answers and feedback.

07.1 · What is the main purpose of a preperformance routine?

- A. Guarantee a particular result.
- B. Remove all uncertainty before action.
- C. Organize preparation and attention for the next task.

07.2 · The available preparation time is much shorter than usual. What should the performer do?

- A. Keep the essential task cue and adapt the sequence to the setting.
- B. Insist on every usual step even if the task has begun.
- C. Replace preparation with a claim of total confidence.

Prepare a short routine

Build a short before-performance sequence. State what each step directs attention toward.

Write two to four sentences using case evidence, a choice and a reason. Save this response for Build.

08 · Notice, reset and return

Use a disruption as a signal for a practical next response.

Learning goal: I can write an adaptable if–then plan that returns attention to useful information.

Before you begin: A reset ends with the task; it is not an endless check of feelings.

Disruption is part of a changing task

A performer may hear an unexpected sound, miss an entry or receive a new instruction. A **reset** is a brief response that helps them return to useful information. It does not erase the event. It creates a bridge from what happened to what the next action needs.

Start with a specific signal. “I am losing focus” is broad. “I keep replaying the last pass and have stopped checking teammates” identifies the pattern more clearly. A useful signal can be noticed without judging the whole person.

Use an if–then plan

An **if–then plan** links a likely event to a response. “If the speaking order changes, then I will confirm when I begin and use my opening cue” is practical. It names both a trigger and an action.

Avoid trying to predict every possible problem. Choose a likely disruption that fits the case. Explain what the performer will do and what information they will attend to next. The response should be brief enough for the setting and should not create a new safety problem.

Notice, adjust, return

One useful sequence is: notice the signal; make a proportionate adjustment during a suitable pause; return to the next task cue. A familiar comfortable breath, release of unnecessary tension or brief cue may be part of the adjustment. None is compulsory for every performer.

The goal is not to force calmness. Do not hold or force the breath, and stop a physical practice if uncomfortable. A written walkthrough is always available. A performer in active play may need to return directly to the relevant external information rather than begin an internal exercise.

When the first response does not fit

A plan should include a check. Did the instruction become clearer? Can the performer identify the next cue? If not, another response may be needed. An unclear role may require a question. An unsafe demand requires a change or appropriate support, not more self-talk.

A reset also differs from denying an error. Useful feedback can be reviewed at a suitable break. The performer does not need to rehearse a whole technical analysis while the next attempt is starting. Separate immediate refocusing from later learning.

Apply the sequence beyond sport

A musician who loses a count may listen for the next agreed entry cue. A student interrupted during a presentation may pause, identify the last completed point and return to the main claim. A recreational participant may ask for the instruction again. The wording changes, but the structure remains connected to the demand.

Judge the plan by its fit, clarity and flexibility. A successful reset is not defined by the learner claiming that every distracting thought disappeared.

Worked example · fictional case**The drill order changes**

The coach changes the drill order before Jordan's turn. Jordan is unsure whether to shoot or join the passing line. The appropriate first move is to clarify the new instruction. A breathing cue would not supply that missing information.

After clarification, Jordan selects the next task cue and begins. The if–then plan is: “If the drill order changes and my role is unclear, then I will ask where to begin, identify the next cue and rejoin the task.”

Notice, reset and return

A short, adaptable sequence during a suitable pause.

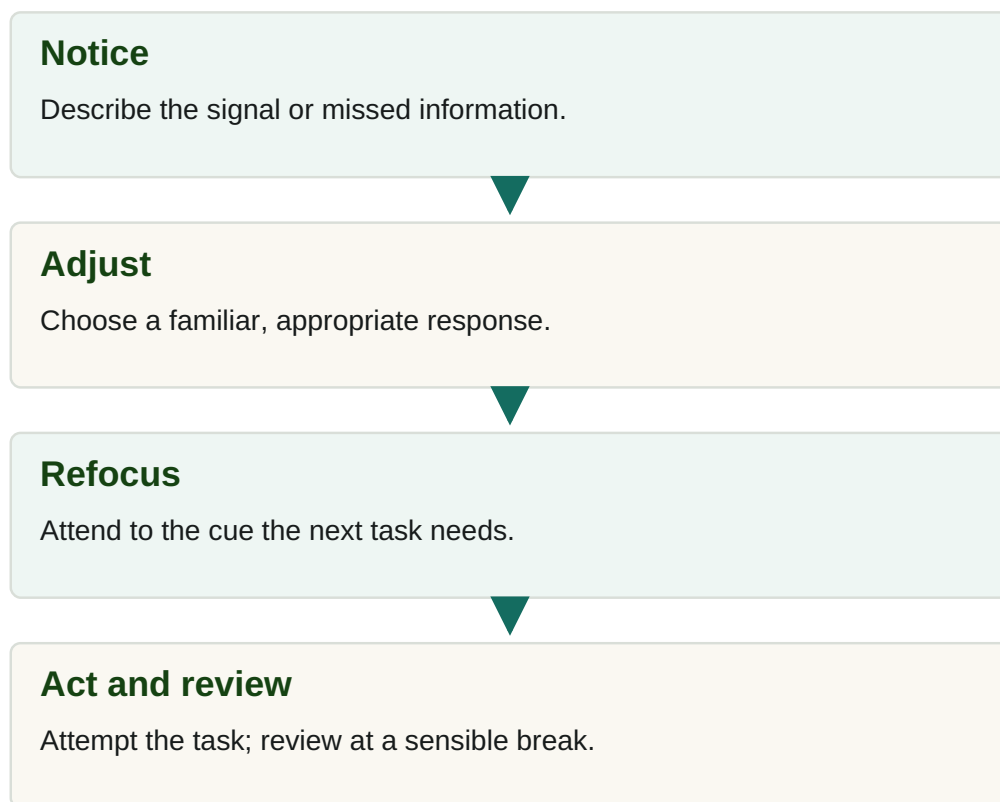


FIGURE 4 · NOTICE, RESET AND RETURN. Notice a specific signal, make an appropriate adjustment, return attention to a task cue, then act and review. The response should fit the situation. A familiar comfortable pause is an option, not an instant off-switch for thoughts or feelings.

Notice a specific signal, make an appropriate adjustment, return attention to a task cue, then act and review. The response should fit the situation. A familiar comfortable pause is an option, not an instant off-switch for thoughts or feelings.

Try the concept checks

Choose before checking. Explanations are in Answers and feedback.

08.1 · Which statement is a usable if–then plan?

- A. If I miss the entry, then I will find the next agreed cue and rejoin there.
- B. If I feel uncertain, then the performance is already lost.
- C. If anything changes, then I will repeat every preparation step.

08.2 · A learner cannot follow the next drill because the instruction is unclear. What fits first?

- A. Assume the learner lacks discipline.
- B. Ask for clarification before choosing the next action.
- C. Use a louder cue without checking the task.

Write an if–then reset

A disruption occurs. Describe the signal, your reset, and what you attend to next.

Write two to four sentences using case evidence, a choice and a reason. Save this response for Build.

09 · Practise a flexible focus plan

Use evidence and one changed condition to refine a plan.

Learning goal: I can propose a suitable variation and explain what evidence would guide an adjustment.

Before you begin: Keep practice hypothetical or appropriately supervised; it is not a punishment.

A plan should travel beyond one familiar setting

A focus plan may work in a quiet practice and need adjusting in another setting. The useful question is not, “Can I force the same feeling everywhere?” It is, “Which information and actions still fit, and which need to change?”

Flexible focus means adapting attention to the task while keeping a clear purpose. It does not mean changing every cue after one mistake. Use evidence to decide which part of the plan needs attention.

Change one condition deliberately

A hypothetical practice can vary the order of turns, the location of a visual cue or the amount of preparation time. Choose a change related to a likely performance demand. State what remains the same so the comparison is understandable.

For actual practice, use appropriate teacher or coach guidance. The variation should not involve humiliation, unsafe distraction or exhaustion as a test of character. You can demonstrate the reasoning through a written case or walkthrough without creating real pressure.

Observe the action before interpreting it

Record what the performer intended to notice and what they actually did. For example: “Jordan looked toward the spectator after the missed shot and did not see the signal.” That observation is more useful than “Jordan has bad focus.”

Then consider possible explanations. Was the signal clear? Had the drill changed? Was Jordan replaying the error? A scenario may provide evidence for one explanation, but a single missed cue does not establish every cause. A strong response identifies both the evidence and its limits.

Decide what to keep and what to adjust

Keep parts of the routine that still serve the task. Adjust the part affected by the changed condition. If the usual visual anchor is hidden, choose another relevant anchor. If the next action is unclear, clarify it rather than simply using the same cue more intensely.

A useful review includes a reason. “I would change the anchor because the usual marker is no longer visible” links the adjustment to evidence. “I would change everything because the attempt missed” makes a much larger claim than the result supports.

Bring the phase together

Your plan should connect the demand, relevant information, attention shifts, cues and a disruption response. It should also distinguish learning-time analysis from a short cue during a familiar attempt. Preparation and feedback remain important even when the performer uses a refocus routine.

In Build, you will use one case to make that connection. In the unfamiliar transfer task, you will keep the useful principles while changing the details. The aim is an explanation that can adapt—not a memorized phrase that only fits one exact question.

Worked example · fictional case

Keep the purpose; change the anchor

A presenter normally uses a highlighted word on a slide as an anchor. In a different room, the display is unavailable. The presenter can use the same key word on a speaking card, then explain the main relationship aloud.

The purpose remains directing attention to the main idea. The representation changes because the usual cue is unavailable. A useful observation is whether the speaker can resume the explanation, not whether they claim to feel exactly as they did in the original room.

A flexible focus plan

Focus is a task-dependent decision.

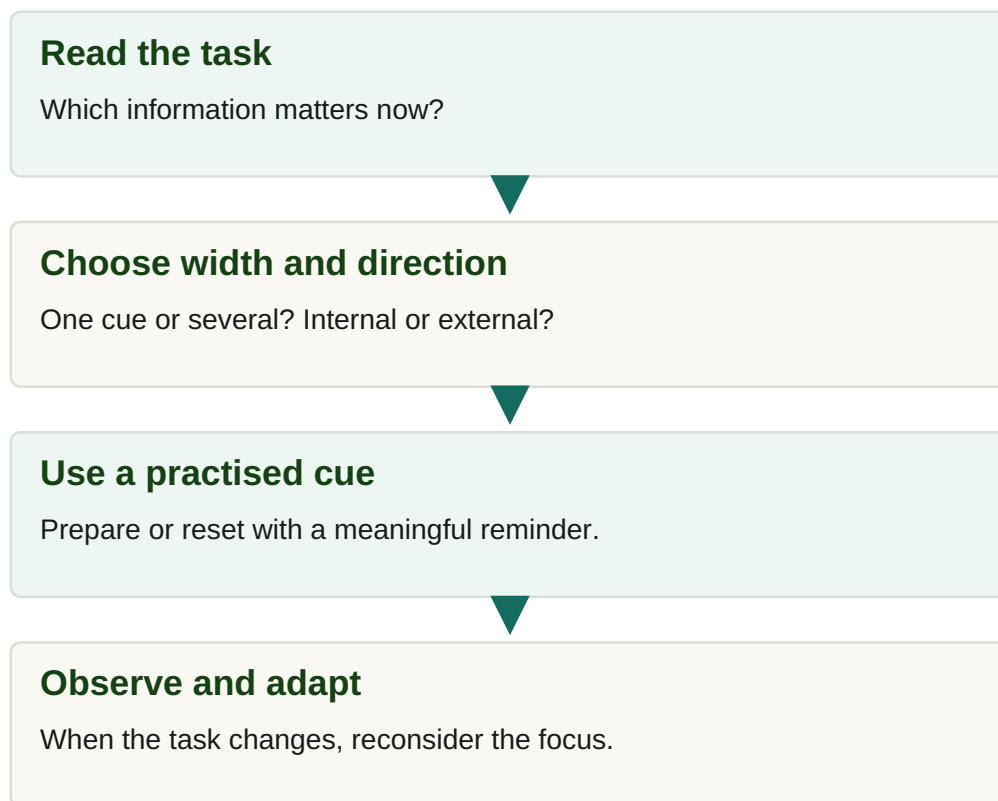


FIGURE 5 · A FLEXIBLE FOCUS PLAN. A flexible focus plan connects the task, the width and direction of attention, a practised cue and evidence for adjustment. Observing a miss alone does not identify one unique attention problem.

A flexible focus plan connects the task, the width and direction of attention, a practised cue and evidence for adjustment. Observing a miss alone does not identify one unique attention problem.

Try the concept checks

Choose before checking. Explanations are in Answers and feedback.

09.1 · What is a useful observation for reviewing a focus plan?

- A. The performer is definitely a low-focus person.
- B. The performer looked at the agreed entry cue before beginning.
- C. The game score proves the performer entered flow.

09.2 · A cue is missed after a change in drill order. Which review is strongest?

- A. Treat the miss as proof that the whole routine failed.
- B. Ignore the changed instruction and use more effort.
- C. Check the instruction, the signal and what the performer attended to before revising one part.

Test a focus plan thoughtfully

Change one condition in a hypothetical practice. What would you observe before deciding whether the plan needs changing?

Write two to four sentences using case evidence, a choice and a reason. Save this response for Build.

10 • Decision practice

Complete all three cases with reasons, then the transfer below. These are the same decisions in the guided and untimed website pathways. The timed game is optional.

Case 1 • The next pass

During open play, Jordan watches the basket but misses a teammate moving into clear space. Jordan says, “I was only thinking about shooting.” The next task is choosing a pass.

- A. Scan the ball, defenders and available teammates.
- B. Keep attention only on the basket.
- C. Review every previous mistake before passing.

Explain: What evidence supports your response? What would you check next?

Case 2 • After a late entry

A singer enters late and thinks, “I am terrible at performing.” The rehearsal leader says the agreed starting count was skipped. The next phrase has a clear entry cue.

- A. Deny that the entry was late.
- B. Describe the skipped count, return to the next entry cue and review the count later.
- C. Treat the mistake as evidence of permanent inability.

Explain: What evidence supports your response? What would you check next?

Case 3 • The display stops

A student is about to explain a graph, but the display stops working. A printed copy is available and the teacher permits its use. The original anchor was a highlighted slide title.

- A. Wait for complete confidence before speaking.
- B. Repeat the same visual routine while staring at the blank screen.
- C. Use the printed graph as an anchor and adapt the opening cue.

Explain: What evidence supports your response? What would you check next?

Transfer the idea

Choose a new sport, academic or artistic situation. Identify a changed demand, the attention it needs and a cue that fits. Explain one observation that would make you adjust the plan.

11 · My Focus Plan

Use the same case throughout. Each field asks for a short structured response, not an essay. Earlier lesson answers can be reused and adapted. The website protects edited Build responses with a replacement confirmation.

The five steps contain twelve required evidence fields. Your teacher evaluates the reasoning and plan, not a self-reported feeling, game score or word count.

Step 1 · Read the situation

Use Jordan or another clearly described fictional performer. Separate the task from your explanation of the difficulty.

Task and changing demand

Describe the performer, task and one moment when the information needed changes.

Distractions and evidence

Identify an internal and an external distraction. Explain the evidence, rather than assuming a cause.

Worked field examples are collected in Answers and feedback. Use them to check the reasoning rather than copy without adapting.

Step 2 · Move attention

Give width and direction, then explain why they fit the task.

Useful focus now

Choose the appropriate focus at one stated moment and justify it.

Three moments and their triggers

Describe at least three moments, their information needs and what triggers each shift.

Worked field examples are collected in Answers and feedback. Use them to check the reasoning rather than copy without adapting.

Step 3 · Prepare a routine

A cue and an anchor are useful when their purpose is clear. Keep the routine short.

Cue examples and selection

Give one instructional and one motivational cue. Select one for the case and explain why.

Anchor and use

Name a return point, when it is used and the next action.

Before-performance sequence

Write a labelled sequence. Explain what each part directs attention toward.

Worked field examples are collected in Answers and feedback. Use them to check the reasoning rather than copy without adapting.

Step 4 · Plan a disruption

Use a realistic interruption. A hypothetical walkthrough is sufficient.

Disruption and response

Name the signal, response and next task cue. Include clarification when instructions are missing.

Walkthrough with a changed demand

Describe one appropriate variation, what stays the same and what the performer would observe.

Worked field examples are collected in Answers and feedback. Use them to check the reasoning rather than copy without adapting.

Step 5 · Review and transfer

Use an observation, not a game score, to explain the plan.

Observation and adjustment

Describe a factual observation and one adjustment it could support. Label invented observations as hypothetical.

Adapt to an unfamiliar task

New case: a musician is moved from a solo to a duet. Explain a changed focus, a useful cue and a disruption response.

Why attention must change

Justify one transition in your plan and explain one limit of what your evidence can show.

Worked field examples are collected in Answers and feedback. Use them to check the reasoning rather than copy without adapting.

Build review criteria

The levels describe evidence, not an automatic numeric grade.

Concept accuracy

Not yet shown: Key ideas are missing or incorrect.

Developing: Some relevant ideas appear, but distinctions need clarification.

Clear: Terms and distinctions are accurate in the stated case.

Thoughtful: Accurate distinctions are carried into a changed situation, with relevant limits.

Evidence and task fit

Not yet shown: The response does not use the case.

Developing: Some evidence is named, but the choice is weakly connected.

Clear: The selected response is supported by relevant case evidence.

Thoughtful: The response weighs relevant evidence and explains why an alternative fits less well.

Usable plan

Not yet shown: The plan is missing or cannot be followed.

Developing: Actions are present but vague or incomplete.

Clear: The sequence, cues and support are specific and workable.

Thoughtful: The plan remains concise while providing a sensible alternative when conditions change.

Reasoning and adaptation

Not yet shown: Reasons and adjustments are not shown.

Developing: A reason or change is suggested without enough explanation.

Clear: Choices and adjustments are explained using the task.

Thoughtful: The response explains tradeoffs, limitations and what evidence would prompt another change.

12 · Written review

Write a first explanation before checking the answer section. Then explain a revision, or explain why the answer fits and add a useful example or limit. The website keeps the first-answer snapshot.

Review 1

Explain how broad/narrow attention differs from internal/external attention. Use one example.

First explanation: two to four sentences.

After comparison: what did you clarify, correct or strengthen?

Review 2

A familiar cue becomes unavailable before a presentation. Explain a useful response.

First explanation: two to four sentences.

After comparison: what did you clarify, correct or strengthen?

Review 3

Correct this claim: “The Inner Game equation calculates potential, and Self 1 and Self 2 are separate brain systems.”

First explanation: two to four sentences.

After comparison: what did you clarify, correct or strengthen?

Review 4

Revisit one lesson response. Describe one useful revision and why it improves your focus plan.

First explanation: two to four sentences.

After comparison: what did you clarify, correct or strengthen?

Final checkpoint

Answer all questions before checking the explanations. The website saves attempts and uses a 70% local practice threshold. This is not a teacher grade or an LMS submission.

1 · A student selects the graph's main relationship, stays with it and shifts to a relevant question. What does this show?

- A. Attention involves selecting, sustaining and shifting according to the task.
- B. Concentration requires one unchanging cue throughout.
- C. Every available detail deserves equal attention.
- D. Attention can only be directed to physical movement.

2 · Why can a long list of corrections be unhelpful during a familiar action?

- A. All technical thinking is harmful in every setting.
- B. Competing instructions can exceed what is useful in that moment.
- C. A learned skill needs no further feedback.
- D. Short cues automatically guarantee success.

3 · A player scans defenders, teammates and open space before passing. Which quadrant fits?

- A. Narrow-internal.
- B. Broad-internal.
- C. Broad-external.
- D. Narrow-external.

4 · During a safe pause, a singer briefly checks one area of jaw tension. Which quadrant fits this moment?

- A. Broad-external.
- B. Broad-internal.
- C. Narrow-external.
- D. Narrow-internal.

5 · How is Gallwey's performance equation used here?

- A. As a coaching framework for discussing interference.
- B. As a calculation of a student's hidden potential.
- C. As a formula proving the cause of every error.
- D. As a replacement for learning a skill.

6 · What do Self 1 and Self 2 name in the attributed framework?

- A. Two separate anatomical brain structures.
- B. The judging/telling role and learned execution.
- C. Two fixed classes of athlete.
- D. A diagnostic score and its treatment.

7 · Which statement keeps useful information without judging the whole person?

- A. I never make mistakes.
- B. I am not a performer.
- C. My setup was rushed; I will use the agreed cue and review it.
- D. The miss proves the routine can never work.

8 · A useful preperformance routine should primarily...

- A. require an identical sequence in every environment.
- B. wait for every nervous feeling to disappear.
- C. replace technical preparation.
- D. connect preparation, a task cue and the next action.

9 · The usual visual anchor is hidden in a new room. What fits an adaptable what-if plan?

- A. Choose another cue serving the same task purpose.
- B. Abandon the performance automatically.
- C. Repeat the old sequence without checking the environment.
- D. Treat the missing cue as a test of personal worth.

10 · Which pairing correctly distinguishes cue purposes?

- A. “Keep going” always teaches a specific movement; “see the target” only raises effort.
- B. “See the target” can be instructional; “commit” can support effort.
- C. All short phrases have the same purpose.
- D. Motivational cues measure bodily activation.

11 · A distracting thought returns during a familiar task. Which response fits this phase?

- A. Require the thought to disappear before acting.
- B. Use the game score to diagnose attention.
- C. Notice the drift and return to a relevant cue when appropriate.
- D. Ignore useful external information to monitor every thought.

12 · Jordan missed a free throw after a rushed setup, then watched a spectator instead of the next signal. Which plan best fits the stated evidence?

- A. Assume every miss proves low ability.
- B. Use the same narrow focus during all open play.
- C. Remove feedback to prevent any analysis.
- D. Use the familiar setup and target cue, then shift to the signal for the next task.

Glossary and sources

Attention

Selecting and using information for a task.

Concentration

Sustaining attention with information that matters.

Task-relevant

Useful for the action or decision currently needed.

Distraction

Information that competes with the current task.

Broad attention

Considering several relevant pieces of information.

Narrow attention

Selecting a specific cue.

Internal attention

Attention to thoughts or bodily sensations.

External attention

Attention to information in the surroundings.

Attention shift

A change in the information selected when the demand changes.

Nonjudgmental observation

A factual description without a verdict on personal worth.

Inner Game

Gallwey's attributed coaching framework for discussing learned execution and interference.

Self 1 / Self 2

Model labels for commentary and learned execution, not brain structures.

Instructional cue

A brief reminder directing technique, timing or information.

Motivational cue

A brief reminder supporting effort or commitment.

Anchor

A chosen return point for attention.

Preperformance routine

A planned sequence connecting preparation to the next action.

If-then plan

A stated disruption linked to a practical response.

Reset

A proportionate response ending with a useful task cue.

Practice variation

A planned, appropriate change in a practice condition.

Transfer

Adapting an idea to a different task or condition.

Sources

Sports Wellness supplied The Focus teaching chapter and task materials. New fictional cases, corrected learner explanations and practice items are authored for this course.

Timothy Gallwey, The Inner Game: the performance framework and Self 1 / Self 2 terminology. Attention quadrants associated with Robert Nideffer, as presented in the supplied Focus material. [The Inner Game](#).

Answers and feedback

Use this section after trying the questions. Compare the ideas and evidence rather than matching every word. Written responses are not automatically marked.

02 · What attention does

Check 02.1: B. The performer remains with the rhythm long enough to complete the phrase. The description does not measure overall capacity.

Check 02.2: C. Several explanations are possible. The task, signal and performer's account help distinguish them.

Written application: look for

- State the exact action or decision.
- Identify one relevant cue and one less useful distraction.
- Explain why the distinction fits this moment.

03 · Four ways to focus

Check 03.1: A. The information consists of several internal options. A pause provides a setting where considering them may fit.

Check 03.2: B. Several external cues are needed for the pass. The other choices leave important task information out.

Written application: look for

- Name the task and moment.
- State width and direction separately.
- Use the actual information in the case to justify both.

04 · Shift as the task changes

Check 04.1: C. A trigger connects the shift to an actual demand. It helps the performer know when the previous cue no longer fits.

Check 04.2: A. The duet introduces information about another performer. The plan needs to account for those cues rather than preserve an outdated sequence.

Written application: look for

- Give a clear setting for each moment.
- Name the information and quadrant.
- Explain what signals each shift and where a step might be unnecessary.

05 · Observe without judging yourself

Check 05.1: B. They are labels used to discuss commentary and learned execution. The lesson does not identify separate anatomical systems.

Check 05.2: C. The response acknowledges a specific error and names a next action. It avoids both denial and a global judgment.

Written application: look for

- Identify the global judgment.
- Keep the observed error without exaggerating it.
- Choose a relevant action and explain the limit of the conclusion.

06 · Cue words and anchors

Check 06.1: A. The cue directs a specific timing feature. It does not measure an internal state.

Check 06.2: B. The anchor serves a function. Another concise reminder can serve that function without turning the routine into a long instruction list.

Written application: look for

- Give one instructional and one motivational example.
- Select the example that fits the stated need.
- Name the anchor, trigger and next action.

07 · Prepare your attention

Check 07.1: C. A routine gives the performer useful actions. The result can still vary and some uncertainty may remain.

Check 07.2: A. A usable routine fits the available moment. Preserve its purpose while adjusting unnecessary steps.

Written application: look for

- State the setting and available pause.
- Give a labelled sequence with a purpose for each step.
- Explain how the final step begins the task.

08 · Notice, reset and return

Check 08.1: A. The plan names a specific event, an appropriate return cue and a next action. It can be practised and adapted.

Check 08.2: B. The problem is missing information. Clarification directly addresses it; a regulation cue does not replace instructions.

Written application: look for

- Name the disruption and observable signal.
- Choose a safe, proportionate response.
- State the next cue and an adjustment if the first response does not help.

09 · Practise a flexible focus plan

Check 09.1: B. The statement describes an action that can be checked. It does not claim a permanent trait or an unmeasured internal state.

Check 09.2: C. The review considers the task and competing explanations. It supports a targeted adjustment rather than an unsupported global conclusion.

Written application: look for

- Name one changed condition and what stays the same.
- State the intended focus and an observable action.

- Explain a proportionate adjustment and one uncertainty.

Decision cases

Case 1: A. The case supplies both the missed information and Jordan's account. A broad-external scan fits the passing decision. It would not be the same focus as a free throw.

Case 2: B. Keep the useful observation and correction. A global judgment does not guide the next phrase. The response joins immediate refocusing with later practice.

Case 3: C. The task still needs an explanation of the graph. An available representation can support it. Changing the anchor preserves the purpose without requiring the original display.

Transfer: identify a genuinely different situation, use its evidence to choose a response and explain a relevant limit or adjustment.

Build field examples

Task and changing demand

Jordan needs a broad scan during open play and a precise target at the free-throw line.

Distractions and evidence

Replaying the miss is internal. Watching a spectator is external. Jordan's account connects these to the missed signal.

Useful focus now

Before the pass, broad-external attention includes available teammates and defenders.

Three moments and their triggers

Open play: scan teammates. Whistle: listen to the official. Free throw: find the chosen rim target.

Cue examples and selection

“See the target” directs attention; “commit” supports effort. Jordan first needs the target cue.

Anchor and use

At the line, the rim target is the anchor. Jordan finds it before following the familiar setup.

Before-performance sequence

Prepare: check the starting position. Direct: find the target and use “smooth.” Begin: take the practised shot.

Disruption and response

If the drill order changes and the role is unclear, ask where to begin, then identify the next cue.

Walkthrough with a changed demand

In a hypothetical practice, shorten the preparation pause. Keep the task the same and check whether the essential target cue is still used.

Observation and adjustment

Hypothetically, Jordan looks away before the signal. Review the trigger for returning to the target rather than label Jordan as unfocused.

Adapt to an unfamiliar task

The duet adds a partner’s timing cue. Plan a shared entry and return point rather than using the solo routine unchanged.

Why attention must change

The passing decision needs several external cues, while a free throw uses a precise target. One missed cue does not identify every possible cause.

Written review

Review 1: Width concerns how much information is selected; direction concerns where it comes from. A player scanning several teammates is broad-external. A brief check of one tension signal during a pause is narrow-internal. The task determines whether either fits.

Review 2: Identify the purpose of the cue and choose an available alternative serving that purpose. A printed keyword may replace a slide title. Explain the next action and check whether the new anchor makes the explanation usable.

Review 3: Gallwey's equation is an attributed coaching framework, not a measurement. Self 1 and Self 2 are labels for discussing commentary and learned execution. The framework does not replace skill learning, task knowledge or useful feedback.

Review 4: A useful revision replaces vague language with a specific task, cue, trigger or observation. For example, "focus more" can become a named scan before a pass. Explain the change and retain a limitation where the evidence does not establish a cause.

Checkpoint explanations

1: A. The task changes from explaining to responding. Selection, sustained attention and a purposeful shift work together.

2: B. The issue is competing jobs in a specific moment. Learning-time analysis and later feedback remain important.

3: C. Several relevant cues in the surroundings make this broad-external attention.

4: D. The selected information is one specific bodily sensation. That describes narrow-internal attention.

5: A. It organizes a discussion. It does not supply measured values or remove other influences on performance.

6: B. These are model labels, not anatomy, diagnoses or permanent learner categories.

7: C. A specific observation supports a next action without denying the error or making a global claim.

8: D. The sequence must fit the task and available time. It supports, rather than replaces, preparation.

9: A. Adapt the representation while preserving the purpose of the anchor.

10: B. Purpose and context determine the distinction. A phrase is not useful merely because it is short.

11: C. The aim is a task-based return, not perfect control of every thought. Real problems may need clarification or support.

12: D. The case identifies a rushed setup and a later attention shift that did not fit the task. The plan addresses both without claiming those facts explain every possible miss.